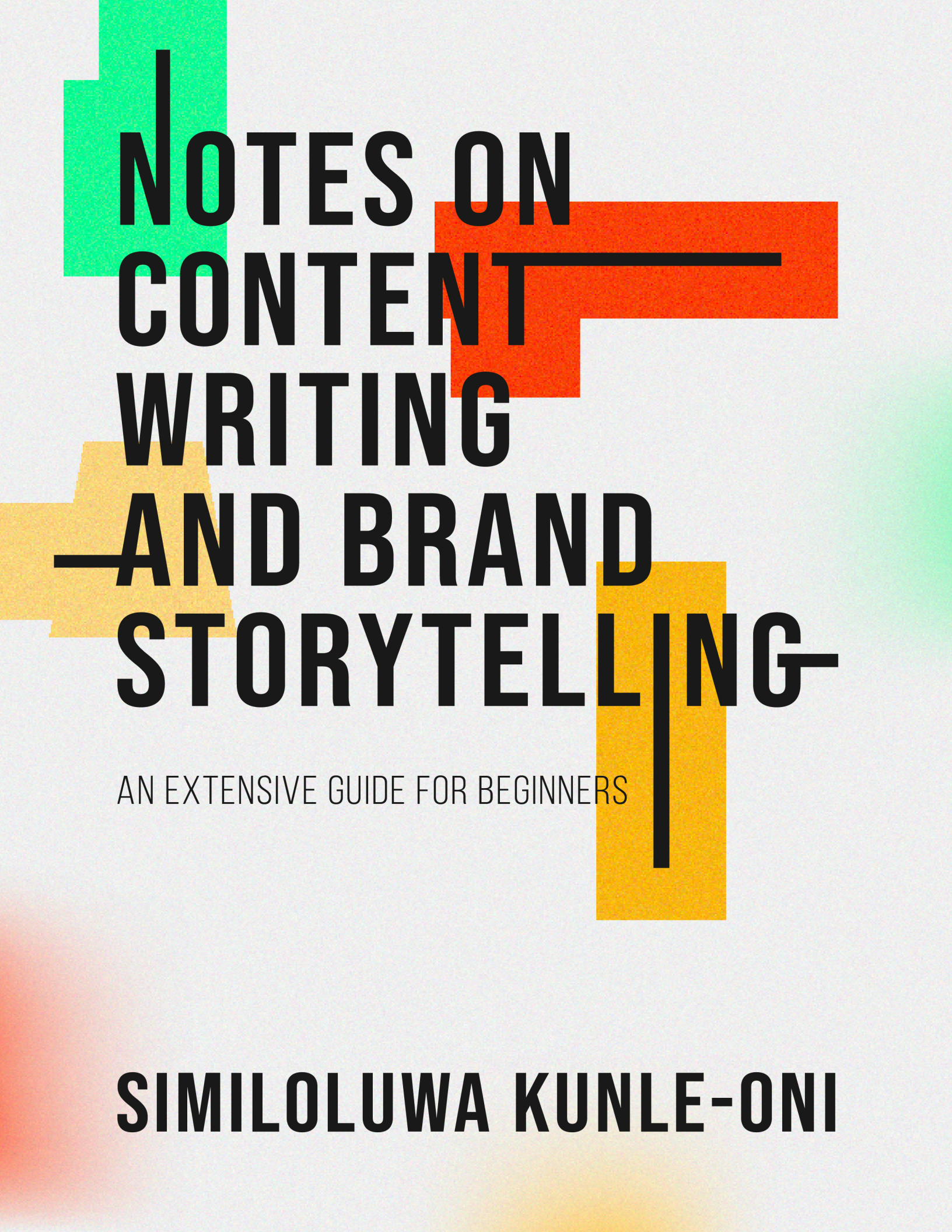




NOTES ON CONTENT WRITING —AND BRAND STORYTELLING—

AN EXTENSIVE GUIDE FOR BEGINNERS

SIMILOLUWA KUNLE-ONI



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For beginners and future wordsmiths.

INTRODUCTION TO CONTENT WRITING

Imagine being able to relate so much to a content that it makes you feel so self aware, it makes you feel like your mind was being read when the author/writer penned the it down. You get that feeling, right? Exactly! That is the effect of content writing; and I'm going to be taking you through it. It's going to be fun!

Content writing is simply the act of writing something so relatable that it keeps an audience engaged. It's the ability to be the pen to the thoughts of others, bringing to life things that they feel, but cannot easily articulate on their own. Hence, putting a spotlight on human behaviors, thoughts and life, in general.

A great part of content writing begins from the writer being self aware. Self awareness to one's experiences, life in general and surroundings.

You should understand that it would be so difficult for you to speak for others when you can't even speak for yourself. You need to be able to observe yourself first before you are able to transform that to the public. The same goes for selling to people. It would be difficult, even nearly impossible, to sell a product that you have no experience using or knowledge of its use.

So, I guess it is safe to say that content writing thrives greatly on awareness, and awareness itself is the basis of relatability.

Is content writing the same as copywriting? This is one question people tend to ask me a lot. Are they the same? Do they mean the same thing? Do they do the same thing? My answer every time is no. Content writing and copywriting are not the same, but they can co-exist. Let me explain.

So, we have established the fact that content writing is the act of writing relatable and engaging content, right? Well, this can transcend into copywriting, which involves content writing, but with an end goal of selling a product or service. Basically, this means that you need to be able to keep people engaged in order to sell to them. People need to be able to relate completely to the product you are selling before deciding to buy it. They also need to feel like you know what it feels like to use the product. Do they think you have a great experience using it or do they think you are simply trying to sell an idea? It's important to tilt towards the former.

Hence, **Copywriting = Content writing + Sale.**

You get it?

Why is content writing so important though? You may ask.

Well, first, you are reading this keenly, so that proves that you find it important lol! You have it registered at the back of your mind that it will be beneficial to you, but there are specific reasons why it is so important, even valuable. Stay with me.

- **Community Building:** Can you tell that this is one of my favorite things about content writing?! Oh this excites me! The community that a content writer is able to build via well-written content is the basis of every other benefit the act comes with. When I first started writing in 2020, I had about a thousand followers, that consisted mainly of friends and family, which is pretty normal. These were also the only people who saw my work, read it and shared on their stories.

At some point, I discovered that more people followed me; people I didn't know, but I found out, with how they communicated with my friends, that they were 'friends of my said friends.' What had happened was that my friends had not only shared my content on their stories, where other people on their timeline could get to view them, they had also shared with their other friends, in their Instagram DMs and even on WhatsApp. That is exactly how you build a community - words of mouth; but in this case, reposts and shares.

But you see, my friends could have shared my content and I wouldn't have gained a single follower if my content was not good or if they didn't relate

themselves. *It is difficult to share something that you do not consider valuable.*

If it is not useful to you, if it doesn't elicit any emotion in you, you will have absolutely no reason to share with others.

So I guess it is safe to say that community building requires good content. It doesn't need to be perfect or outlandish, it just has to be good.

- **Brand Storytelling:** This is the heart of marketing! It is simply a way through which the seller focuses on creating a connection with potential buyers, in order to sell a product to them, but more importantly, to create a relationship with them.

Now, how do we build that connection, you may ask? By content writing! Like I mentioned previously, it is so difficult to sell to people that do not feel like they can relate with you. One of the things that brand storytelling focuses on, the most, is making the potential buyer aware of the problem that their product is trying to solve. There is an attention shift from the product — which is the solution — to the problem and how it affects the potential buyer.

For example, I, as a brand storyteller, will focus more on how doing one's laundry manually is so stressful and demanding, than focus on me trying to get you to buy the washing machine that my client sells. I'm putting all my energy into making you see how strenuous the whole process of washing, rinsing and drying is, rather than making a list of the benefits of using a washing machine. Basically, I am telling a story about the problem and in that way, making you

see reasons why you need a more efficient, less strenuous alternative to doing your laundry manually. When I am able to make you aware of the problem, I then introduce a solution to you, suggestively. It would feel like you made the decision on your own because, yes you did, but a large part of that decision is attributed to how well I have been able to sell the problem, rather than the solution.

People relate more to problems than to solutions.

- **Copywriting:** Remember when we mentioned that copywriting is simply ‘Content writing + Sale’? Good. You have a great memory, I like that. So essentially, for you to be able to be a great copywriter, you need to be an even better content writer.

People find it so difficult to purchase a product they see no reason to own. They also do not see a point in reading a copy that they do not connect to. People need to read your copy before they decide on buying what you are selling, right? So make them a good copy that they are eager to read. Make your copy so relatable that they want to engage with it, that they do not begin to read and end up losing attention while reading it. Write something that keeps them stuck until you make a sale to them that they cannot resist, all because you’ve been able to keep them engaged!

A great copy makes a sale, but that great copy requires irresistible content.

- **Earn a living:** The whole point of learning a skill is to earn a living from it, to be a baller and afford the lifestyle you want, haha! Yes, that skill might be something you are passionate about but that passion won't pay your electricity bills or rent; money will! So, if you are learning how to be a content writer, what is the end goal for you? I'll answer. Money! In most cases, 'doing' becomes more interesting and less tiring when you can make money off it. Imagine doing years of hard work and not being able to think of a time when you made thousands from that hard work. That is demoralizing.
Money needs to be earned and content writing will help you do just that!

There you go! Four great importances of being a content writer. Very convincing, aren't they?

With every act, there are principles.

Let's take a look at the principles of content writing!

- **Authenticity:** The need for authenticity can never be overemphasized. I can tell you, for a fact, that one of the worst things to hear as a writer is, "Your work looks or sounds exactly like X's."

Of course, when starting out as a writer, you try to mirror what works already, from the style that already-successful writers adapt, to the things they write about. Your brain registers that as the most acceptable form of writing, because it has passed the stage of experimentation and has been tested to work. So you follow suit. You write like them, use the same intonation they use, write on the same topics they write about - until it becomes tiring and unsustainable. You then realize that you need to write something that feels like you. Something fresh. You will also discover that you may love the same topics that more experienced writers tilt towards, but your manner of delivery is different. Your work possesses a *je nais se quois* that you grow to love and people can relate more to, because it is your work and it is your voice! The only way to find your authentic voice, if it isn't something already available to you, is to consistently try what you feel will work for you. Maybe even consistently try everything. Experiment!

There is no harm in trying until you own and hone your voice, but there is harm in constantly sounding like someone else and losing your writing power - authenticity.

- **Simplicity:** When I was growing up, I read a lot of books. The one book that stood out the most, to me, was Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus*. I read the book at a young age of 10 or 11, and the reason why I was able to read that book at that age was because it was written in simple terms and tenses. One of the things I would always love about CNA is how simple her work always is. I discovered early in life that the only way to get people to feel things with your work is by writing something that they can easily understand at first glance. If people have to read your work over again, for the sake of clarity, it proves to you that you have not been able to capture their hearts and minds with your writing. Simplicity breeds clarity and clarity makes your work relatable. You can never go wrong with making your words easy to understand. There is no point, whatsoever, in using bulky, complex words that people have to take unnecessary looks at in the dictionary.

The world's attention span is very short, there is no time for your work to be anything but simple and clear.

- **Utilize active/catchy headlines and intros:** A great part of content writing is grabbing attention. This can only be done by utilizing catchy headlines and intros, and this would be of great advantage to you when you are transforming a written content to a copy or story. A headline as simple as 'Eight ways to be a big spender,' can lead to more numbers than a headline that says 'Eight ways to have a lot of money.' The former sounds more friendly, more relatable, hence catchy, while the latter sounds like something you read in an Economics textbook. A large part of the digital market consists of two generations - Gen Z

and Millennials, and if you are trying to reach these two, you need to be as catchy as possible. It's even more essential because content from these two generations can transcend to other generations, so it's best to keep it catchy.

Be active!

- **Know your audience:** One thing I am going to be emphasizing on going forward, is the importance of knowing your audience. A good knowledge of your audience will take you places, figuratively and literally. There is no way you can effectively strategize your content to sell if you do not know who the content is for. You will be spending a lot of brainpower on lost content, if you do not decide on your target. *'Lost,' because your content will be pointed at everybody, hence nobody!*

So you have to decide who your content is for. What demographic are you targeting? What class of people? When you know these, it becomes easier for you to relate to them in the best way. The choice of language becomes easier to make and you get a step closer to connecting with your audience, building a community and selling to them.

- **Do your research:** When I started off in content writing, I wrote purely based on/off excitement. When I got ideas on what to write, I typed them out and posted them on a whim. My content lacked research - I barely fact-checked or edited. The downside about this is that people who are meant to be on the receiving end of your 'good content,' become the same people who edit your

work for you. One time in 2020, I made a baseless statistical assumption in an attempt to sound like I knew exactly what I was saying. To me, I was just trying to make my point more valid, but to others, it was... baseless. Would it have cost me anything to do a quick fact-check on Google, or would the content have thrived without the 'baseless' information? Yes, it would have. Saying 'most people' is more credible than saying '90% of people,' because you needed to have done a survey to come up with that number.

If your content can do without it, exclude it. If it is vital to your content, include it. If you are not sure of the information you have in your content, do your research!

Of course, the above principles will definitely pivot your career as a content writer. Are you having fun learning? I'm excited. Let's learn more!

Your job as a content writer can come in various forms.

Here are a popular, yet essential few:

- **Blogging:** One of the most popular forms that content writing comes in is blogging, i.e, writing fun, relatable blogposts, which can be articles or interviews. Your ability to write great content will come in handy while writing blogposts.
- **Script writing:** Podcasts, YouTube videos, TV shows, movies and radio shows all thrive on well-written scripts. A lot of visual or audio content are birthed from relatable, engaging content. If it sounds good on paper, it sounds good on air or on video!
- **Newsletter writing:** Newsletters make up one of the fastest growing forms of marketing. Although newsletters do not need bulky texts, well-written content is essential. Straight-to-the-point, relatable, engaging content that makes the readers want to tap on links and buy your products.
- **Social media content writing:** The most popular form of content writing! Now, it is no news that the market has gone digital and the best way to sell is to be digital too. A vast majority of potential buyers exist on social media, and in order for you to build a community or sell to the said majority, it is essential for you to keep them informed - this is where content writing comes in!

- **Ebook writing:** A grown part of content writing is ebook writing. As the world gets more digitalized, more people are opting for digital products. Ebooks on any and everything now exist and the fun part about this is that the surface is only being scratched. As intense as the digital effect may seem, there is still more exploits to be made on the digital front. Now, an ebook is great, but a well-written ebook that keeps the reader engaged wins in the end. Whether the ebook is fictional or nonfictional, the goal is to keep the reader engaged!

Wow! What an introduction! We still have a lot of exciting things to learn! Let's go!!!

WRITING WITH FLAIR

Have you ever read a piece of work that kept you stuck all through till the end? It was so impossible for you to take breaks and you savored every moment reading. Every word felt like life and every statement evoked an emotion in you. You know what made you feel that way? Flair.

It sounds so feather-like and light, and that is exactly its aim - to make your content feel light enough to pass through the reader's mind smoothly, without confusion.

You need to always remember that what sticks to the minds of your readers is the *structure, flow and body of your work*.

Here are a few reasons why it is important to write with flair:

- **Creator's pride:** Remember when God created everything in the world and when He was done, He looked at it all and concluded that they were very good? Exactly! What He felt in that moment was satisfaction, pleasure and pride in His creation. We have the ability to create too, to write in ways that evoke feelings in people and when you succeed in doing that, you feel that pride too.

One of the greatest pleasures as a writer is seeing people respond to my content the exact way I predicted they would or loving the content just as much as I do. I feel creator's pride. That is the number one reason why I love writing with flair, to be honest. It's just so surreal to be able to make people feel things with

my words.

- **A growing community:** One thing great writing would definitely do is bring more readers to your community. The power of reposts and shares. It is impossible for people to gatekeep valuable content, so when they find yours as such, it comes naturally to share with others. What this leads to? More followers. More reach. More impressions. All targeted at giving you a larger community. It is not rocket science really. A great, well-written content that possesses flair would definitely give you a stronger, larger community.
- **It builds anticipation and excitement in your readers:** I love when I read an article or content from someone and then I am looking forward to the person's next content. I become excited to see more. The anticipation grows and whenever their content pops up, I am clicking on the like button, even before reading. Good content makes me excited, for real. And I know you feel that way too. The reason why we feel like that about people's content is because we have established a connection with them; it's not just about reading anymore, it is now a culture!
- **Your content could go viral:** Now, isn't this one of writers' greatest wishes now? The thrill that comes with thousands of people seeing your content, bloggers reposting your content, WhatsApp users reposting on their stories. All of a sudden, your content is on everyone's story! That sounds super good, doesn't it? Well, for you to be able to go viral someday, you need to be able to

consistently write content that has flair. A content without flair is *just* a piece of information.

- **You become a great brand storyteller:** How do people tell brand stories that sticks to the minds of people? It's pretty simple. Flair. Whether it is a script for a visual advert or a written brand story itself, flair is a key ingredient in building a connection with your potential buyers. You are focusing on your potential buyers when writing a brand story, so write something that strikes their emotions, that makes them look forward to your next story and their next purchase.

Now that we've discussed why flair is so important in writing, how about we talk about the ways by which you can write with flair? LOL

It would be unfair for me to tell you 'to do,' without telling you 'how to do,' no?

- **Make use of active sentences in your work:** There is absolutely no reason to stress your readers with passive sentences when you can easily opt for active sentences. Actives are what give life to your writing. Passives make it seem like you are having a slow conversation on a bad day.

Passive: My phone was taken upstairs by me at 8:45pm

Active: I took my phone upstairs at 8:45pm.

See the major difference? One makes you want to keep listening to the writer or

speaker, the other makes you desire to not hear from the writer / speaker again. Active sentences are *so* important.

- **Punctuate properly:** When I mastered the use of punctuation in storytelling, I knew it was over! *chuckles* You become untouchable in writing when you can punctuate properly. What proper punctuation does for you is that, it makes it easier for your readers to connect with you, because your writing feels more like a journey for them. Nobody wants to read a displaced content or article, anyway. It starts from you writing like you would speak; if it doesn't sound good when voiced, something must change!

A lot of speeches or articles feel like the best things in the world because the writer or speaker knows when to take pauses (comma), to stop (period), to pause, but not long enough to feel like a stop (semi-colon). The knowledge of all these and more are what keeps a writer / speaker power over their own work and an ability to influence the minds of their readers / listeners.

Want proof? Listen to Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's speeches.

- **Keep your sentences short:** I learnt earlier on, when I first decided to make writing a profession, that long sentences are not sustainable in writing. In fact, they are unnecessary. The goal is to have more sentences, more paragraphs, with less words in them. Now, what this helps you with is that it makes it easier for your readers to consume your content. The first thing that comes to my mind when I see long sentences and paragraphs is fear. I'm usually like, "Oh my! Who's going to read all this? It looks so scary," but when I see short

sentences and short paragraphs, I become relieved. My attention span automatically decides to live through it.

Now, apps like Twitter have a character limit that helps people to keep their paragraphs short. For Twitter, it is a 280-character limit. In this way, it is easier to read a tweet and not lose interest. If it is a thread, it is easier for people to move on to the next tweet because it is impossible for them to get bored easily with a character limit.

I guess that is why I love using Twitter, if we're being honest. I let someone else regulate my characters for me. Isn't that great?

If you are not interested in using Twitter, you should make sure that in whatever design or form you find suitable, you make use of short sentences and paragraphs, still.

- **Keep it simple:** The need for simplicity in your work can never be overemphasized. This is the only way for people to understand you at a glance and not have to go through the pangs of searching the dictionary because of a content they read during a busy work day. You have people's attention sparingly, maximize it. Keep your words simple. This is one of the surest ways to activate flair in your work.

Do you understand what it means to write with flair, now? Do you see how important it is? Yes? Great! No? You can go over the above again. Don't worry, you'll get it. Take your time.

HOW TO WRITE ENGAGING CONTENT

Let us now take an in-depth look into the act of writing engaging content. But first, let's dive into the **properties of an engaging content**.

- **It sparks conversation:** This is probably the easiest way for you to know that your content is engaging. You notice your readers passing their opinions of your content in the comment section and you also catch people replying to other readers' comments. So your readers are not only communicating with you, they are also communicating with other readers!

Another way conversation is sparked is through shares. Now, if you don't know, you are able to view the insights of your posts when you switch your Instagram account to a professional account. On Twitter, you are able to view the activity, while on blogs and newsletters, e.g. Substack, Medium or Wordpress, you will be informed in cases of shares.

People sharing your work with friends, family and even frenemies, tells you that your content is super engaging, because conversations have been sparked!

- **It's timeless:** Believe it or not, there are content I wrote way back in 2021 that I can post today, in 2023, because they are still engaging! This is attributed to the timelessness of great content. If your work is engaging and relatable, it will always be engaging and relatable. Which is why, as much as it is great to write on trends, it is even greater and sustainable to write with intention, with a

longterm, sustainable goal in mind.

- **It can easily be grasped:** This is where simplicity comes in, once again. You see how important simplicity is? We have mentioned it multiple times now and as much as it may sound cliché, it is vital and it works! Aspire to be simple always. The only thing complexity will do for you is *nothing*.

- **Different people relate to it in different ways:** There is a satisfaction that comes with knowing that ten different people relate to your content in ten different ways. Now, don't feel pressured, okay? LOL.

This mostly happens when you have a carousel/list of multiple slides explaining a situation in multiple ways. In a situation where different people pick different slides as the most relatable to them, just know that you have won at carousels or lists. Congrats!

Let's now take a look at the tips on how to write engaging content!

This should be fun!

- **Know your audience and communicate like them:** The first thing you need to do when writing an engaging content is to know your audience. A lot of people decide on what audience they want based on what they enjoy writing about, while other people decide on the demographic they are trying to reach and then write based on/off that. Either one you choose is fine, as long as you speak the language of your audience. If you want to engage with them, you need to communicate just like them.

For example, when communicating with gen z and millennials, you know that TikTok lingos and more relaxed words are commonly used lol. So you have to communicate with more relaxed, fun and simple languages.

- **Always make use of a suggestive tone:** You don't want to go around making people feel like you are trying to force certain opinions down their throats. You need to be as suggestive as possible. You know this common thing where people say, "I give advice to people and then I end it with 'that's just how I feel though' or 'just saying'"? Exactly! Your tone of communication should make people want to consider your opinions. For you to engage people, you need to make them feel like they have a say in your content. If not, you end up shooting yourself in the foot.

A suggestive tone would also save you from backlash when your opinions are not so accurate, but if you behave or write like you know it all, people are

going to 'drag' you. This is the internet; you need to tread carefully.

- **Own the story:** The easiest way to make people engage with your work is by speaking from your own experiences. People resonate more with you when they feel like you have an idea of what you are speaking about. And the thing about writing is that, when you put your emotions and feelings into it, people are able to feel those exact emotions you felt when you were writing. So, own the story. You are more relatable that way.
- **Don't overthink it:** Overthinking is one thing that stunts your growth as a writer. Yes, be rational with your content, but also loosen up. Open yourself up to ideas and just write. Write however you feel and as long as you are writing for your audience and it is not controversial or harmful, you are good! Editing your content is different from overthinking it. Editing makes your work better, overthinking makes your work non-existent. Just write.

I really enjoyed this topic. I hope you did too! Let's move on to the next chapter, shall we? Yes, we shall! *chuckles*

THE USE OF GRAPHIC DESIGNS IN CONTENT WRITING

This chapter is majorly for writers who are interested in social media content writing or for writers who employ the use of graphics in their blogs or newsletters.

It is an important topic to discuss because writing is as delicate as its display.

A content can be well-written but at the end of the day, possess little to no engagement because of its display. And when picking the right design or display to show off your work, you want to prioritize legibility and minimalism.

Here are a few notes for legibility:

- **The font used should be large enough for your readers to see at first glance:**

You definitely do not want your readers to be squinting to read what you wrote, so make sure that the font size is large enough to be read at first glance.

Your content is way more pleasing and attractive to read when it is actually readable.

- **The font style should not be too dramatic:** As much as we may be tempted to go all-out with font styles, we should also keep things simple. Use simple fonts that can be easily read and understood by people. Remember that the focus

should be on the content, so keep the dramatic font styles for later.

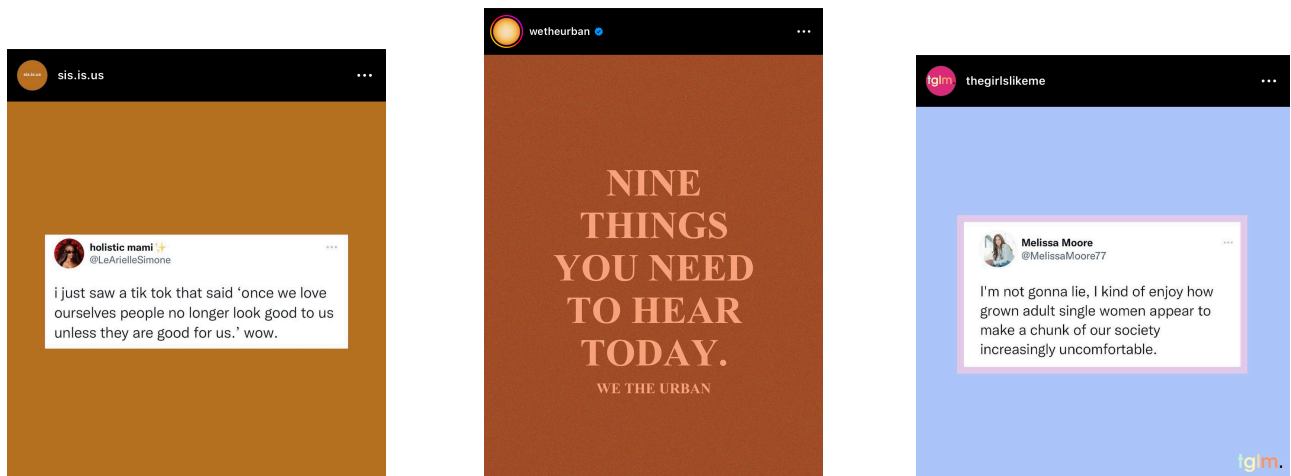
- **The words on a design should not be too many:** When applying designs in content writing, always ensure that the word count on each poster is not over-the-top. Keep the words at a reasonable number, because like we have established, you want to write something that flatters the attention span of internet users, not irritate them.
- **The color palette should be minimal:** There is no need experimenting with too many colors, especially the loud ones. The attention of your readers should be on the written content and they should not be distracted by your color palette. Make use of earthy / natural tones that will help accentuate your content and not make it look messy.

We've established the need for legibility and minimalism, now, let's get into **the why?** Why is graphic design necessary? Is it even necessary at all, in writing? Let's go!

To be very honest, for me as a writer, I am not very big on graphic designs. I have gone through the phase of utilizing numerous colors in writing and I am presently in that period where I just transfer tweets from Twitter to Instagram, after making a little adjustment to the size measurement. So, for someone who

has been through the design phase, I can tell you, for a fact, that it isn't completely necessary for personal branding.

For community pages where you aren't sharing just your personal opinion, you should make use of designs so your page stands out, but for your own personal page where you share your random thoughts, it isn't totally necessary.



Images: Community pages with minimal graphic designs

When I first started writing, I switched colors a lot and what I discovered this did, besides me focusing so much on the design than I did on the writing, I was being plagiarized a lot. People would take my content and crop out my name, so they can repost as theirs. That's so wicked, by the way! I went through that multiple times and then I decided that I had had enough of plagiarism and

screaming on my story every day to be given credit for my work. It was wild, fr lol!

So what I did was, I maximized the use of my Twitter account. It is so rare to see a tweet author's username being removed or cropped out from the content. It is so rare. So it became a case that even though I may not be given credit for my work in mentions or tags by every blog, my name would be visible!

Not saying that there aren't sick people who would still decide to take your intellectual work, but you are at a lesser risk when you make use of simple tweets.

The focus should never be shifted from the content. That is all that matters — your content. Every other thing is just an addition and should be treated as such.

BRAND STORYTELLING

This is one of the juiciest topics ever! Brand storytelling is such a unique way of selling products or services. And I think the best part of it is that it has a lot to do with emotions. It involves you, as a storyteller, connecting with your audience or potential buyers. It is the fact that the focus is shifted from the product to the potential buyers. Something about that is giving “I know you love me” energy! It’s giving “I love that you think of me.” It’s such a compelling, persuasive and narrative, yet selfless approach to selling. Don’t you just love that? Well, I do!

Brand story telling has three major purposes.

They are:

- **Creates brand awareness:** Prior to selling to people, they need to be aware of your brand and what it has to offer. Although, brand storytelling does not actively target selling, it targets awareness, first, which converts to sales.

Creating the knowledge of what the product has to offer and what problems the product or brand is targeting, is key in brand storytelling. A great brand story will do your bidding for you, will market you to the world without you doing too much. All you need is to be able to connect with people who will help create an awareness for you, with no hassle, by sharing with their circles or communities.

Hence, A great brand story = Massive engagement = Brand awareness.

- **Boosts brand perception:** How people perceive your brand determines how they are ready to receive it. If you do not create a great perception of your brand, it would be difficult for you to sell to people. So, the goal is to create a great brand perception. This is done by telling compelling, emotion-evoking stories that will create an inkling in your audience's minds. Make them feel and the selling would do itself!
- **Influences sales:** Of course, the main focus of a story is the potential buyers/ audience, the end goal still remains to sell. The brand story does the marketing for you, which leads to sales! So, brand awareness leads to great brand perception, hence SALES. All these achieved by telling stories that make people feel.

Now that we've talked about the purpose of brand storytelling, **let's discuss the steps involved in writing great brand stories.**

We'll be taking a look at this in **4 different highlights** that bring about results.

The highlights are:

- **Attention:** Your first task in writing a great brand story is to capture the attention of readers. Remember that they are readers before they becomes potential buyers and then, finally, buyers — provided you succeed in connecting to them. So to catch their attention, what you need to utilize are catchy headlines, catchy intros, catchy first paragraphs. Something that draws

the attention of the readers. Something that screams, “READ ME, YOU WILL ENJOY THIS!”

The first encounter is what helps the reader to decide if they are interested in continuing their read or watching or listening, as the case may be.

- **Interest:** This is the part where you connect with your audience. This is the point where you would usually introduce a problem to them or make them aware of an already existing problem. Now, remember to maintain a suggestive tone when doing this. You are making them aware of a problem, yes, but do it suggestively, and in a tone that makes them know that you care. At this stage, the solution, which is your product, has not been introduced to them yet, but in the next stage, you make your readers potential buyers.
- **Desire:** In this stage, the readers evolve into potential buyers. This is where you introduce the product or service to them as a solution, while still keeping them interested and prioritizing their needs. This prepares you for the action.
- **Action:** This is the part where you call your potential buyers to action. Where you convert potential into reality. A clear call to action such as “Click on the link in bio to get” or “Sign up now” is going to do a lot for your sale. Don’t just tell them to get it, tell them how to do it too. Call them to it. When you do this, you can rest assured you’ve made a sale!

Now, let's have a look at an example of brand story written for a client from the perspective of a freelance writer.

Case Study: A laundry equipment brand, called Wash-It.

One of the things I detest the most, after doing the dishes, is doing laundry. I don't know who came up with that chore but whoever did should know that me and my people are not happy about it! Imagine the stress, the sweat and the manpower it takes to wash clothes. Imagine coming up with a method where you use your hands to scrub your clothes until they become paper thin. Why?

The other day, I had to split my clothes into six batches across the week, so that it would 'seem' easier to wash. Oh I thought this was a great idea until after the end of that week, I had more clothes to wash. why did I even think of doing a thing like that?

Anyway, I have decided that this is simply struggling, and if there is anything I am not spending my 2023 doing, it is struggling! So I'm not interested I doing my laundry myself. I am entering into my soft life. It is no longer my hands that will be soft. It is my life!

And do you know how I am going to achieve that? Wash-It! I really just ordered for laundry equipment from them and I am going to let this equipment wash, rinse and dry for me. How did I not find out about this from the jump? Why did you guys keep this from me?

Anyway, I'm not going to cast blames... yet. I'm just here to let you guys know that I have chosen the soft life and you should too! Click on the link in my bio now, to order for your own laundry equipment. Let's Wash-It!

From the above example, you will see that the first paragraph draws your attention, the second and third paragraph spark your interest in the story, the forth paragraph makes you desire the product and the fifth paragraph, which is the last, calls you to action!

You will also notice that I tried to avoid a few things.

- I avoided unnecessary information that would not have flattered my story: Too much information would have led to tardiness.

- I avoided a forceful tone: My point is suggestive. More like encouraging. And also humorous.
- I avoided a pleading tone: In as much as I would love for others to get the laundry equipment, I made sure I exercised value. A pleading tone would make it seem as though I am trying too hard to sell. Yes, the product will be great for the audience/potential buyers, but I also need to maintain a sense of luxury around the laundry equipment.
- I avoided confusion: My call to action is clear and precise. There are no loopholes and clarity is ensured.

Note: Can you see that I personalized the story? In that way, I was able to make the story more human and that approach is more intentional with the consumer/potential buyer in mind.

Although the importance of a great brand story is glaring enough from what we've discussed so far, you can now see that the best way to influence buyer's decision is via great brand storytelling, because once the story is told right, the buyer's perception of the brand takes a great turn in a positive way.

Also note that you can employ the Attention-Interest-Desire-Action tool as an in-house content writer in an organization. Spin it to your taste!

CONTENT EDITING

If you've gotten here, congratulations!

Since you've gotten an extensive look into content writing, let's dive into content editing!

This is a vital part of content writing, because you can have a great content, copy or story but the content ends up not being engaging or you receive backlash or criticism, instead of reception. The best way to ensure that your work is both great and well-received is by editing, by revising your work over again to ensure that there are no errors.

As a content writer, you cannot afford to just write based on/off of excitement. Excitement is good, but it can also be dangerous. I mean, when you get certain ideas that are so good, you tend to rush off to put them into reality. You feel like they would do well, so you don't commit time into analyzing your content or copy multiple times, to ensure that there are no errors.

At the end of the day, you discover that your work requires more research, some statements you included are not necessary or that your work still needs to be fleshed out.

To avoid regret from seeing an avoidable mistake, it is best to take your time to edit.

Let me take you through a simple, yet useful process of editing that I apply.

- When writing, I try to look at my sentences or paragraphs after writing them. So, say I am writing a 10-paragraph content, I take ten pauses to analyze each paragraph to check for errors. This is called line editing. I do this to ensure that my language is clear as I go.
- Now, when I am done writing, I read the entire body of work to myself to check the flow and structure. I try my possible best to read the content out loud even if this can be cringe *chuckles* I do this because reading inwardly will not make me see the mistakes made, and also because my mind is focused on what I meant when writing, rather than what I was meant to write, hence I need to hear what I have written, loud and clear.
- Sometimes, when I am done with the above two, I try to leave the content for a few minutes, say 5-10 minutes; then I read it again. You'll be shocked to know that who you were five minutes ago is different from who you are now. After 5 minutes, analyze your content, ask yourself if the content is necessary or relevant at that period, too. If your answers are affirmative, then you can proceed with making your content public!
- Now, the final process in editing is the one I make after posting or publishing. Bearing in mind that there are some errors that seep into your work even after making certain edits, it is imperative to check your work again within the first minute of posting. You are checking to see if there are errors you omitted when you were editing. If there are any errors that are detrimental to your content, it

is advisable you pull the content down immediately and then post again, shortly after or later, just whenever you feel suits your audience.

Like I said, these points may seem simple but they are life changing. They save you from a lot of bad criticism and regret.

Now, let's take a full look into the types of content editing we have.

These will give you a broader look into content editing. Stay with me, okay?

- **Developmental editing:** This is more significant in editing manuscripts and books, but can also be relevant in editing content and copies too. This is where you decide whether the idea behind the content is important enough to be published or shared.

You see, you can decide to have a totally random content with the sole aim of being witty, but other times when the content is in a more serious tone, it is best to analyze the idea and know for sure that it is the best thing to write and it is written in the best form.

- **Line editing:** As discussed in the process of editing I mentioned earlier, line editing has to do with revising the sentences in your content to ensure it is well-written and as clear as possible. So you're tightening up loose ends and making sure that your work is readable.

Another thing line editing helps with is the flow of your content. When

changes have been made to every line, it becomes easier to maintain a great flow and style. Every sentence flows directly into next, making it super enjoyable for your audience to read.

- **Fact-checking:** Research is super important in writing. Whether you are a lifestyle writer, relationship and wellness writer, brand storyteller, etc, it is essential to do your research. Have fun with writing, but check if your information are facts. You don't want to be riddled with regret after posting or have critics dissect your work for you in a harsh way. It would cost nothing to do a quick fact-check of your work.
- **Proofreading:** This is the stage where you look at the final draft after making all other edits. Here, you check for every error, from punctuation to spelling, grammar, etc. The main aim of this is to prove that your content is ready to be published or shared with the world.

These may seem a bit tasking, but remember that you're not trying to just put out content, you are trying to put out *good* content!

FAQS ON CONTENT WRITING

I'm sure you have some questions looming in your mind, so I am going to answer some frequently asked questions I have been asked in the past.

1. *"I am a very shy person and I find it difficult to put my work out there, on social media or blogs. What do you advise I do?"*

— When I started writing content, I made sure to not post my pictures because I was so shy and scared (I don't know why I was scared lol). I think more shy than scared. And I didn't want my page to look tacky, I am big on coordination and coordination can be time-consuming and stressful, so I decided to not post my pictures at all. I think a year into content writing, I was more into displaying my pictures, so I just went with it.

I guess what I am trying to say is, most times, this fear of putting oneself out there stems from how you feel people would view your opinions and relate it back to you as a person, so you can decide to test the waters a bit, by not posting your pictures at the start, so more attention is on your work, or you can create a separate page for your work entirely. Whichever works best.

2. *"So I understand that content writing brings engagement but I don't know what to write about and I'm not sure people are going to like my content. What do you think?"*

— So I always tell people one thing and that is, "You can't improve on nothing." It is impossible to improve on what does not exist. Hence, just start writing. Literally, just start! With time, you will get better, and to be fair, there

is no such thing as bad content these days, there is harmful content, there is controversial content, but never bad content. As long as your content is neither harmful nor controversial, you are good. Just keep writing. You'll do great.

3. *"Is it compulsory for me to niche my audience?"*

— Depending on what your goals are, you can decide to create a niche with your content or just target everything lifestyle.

People niche their content to get more gigs from brands. You know, if it is clear that this is the type of content they put out, it becomes easier for brands to approach them. For example, a skincare content writer would get a lot of gigs from skincare brands than a lifestyle content writer, who talks about skincare occasionally. So, if your intention is to get more gigs or if you have passion for a single topic, then create content for a particular niche. If you are not so interested in that, you can decide not to. Whatever works best and whatever you are most comfortable with is fine.

4. *"How can I decide the tone of my content?"*

— It's an established note in this ebook that your tone of voice or method of writing must always be suggestive. It is important to be more informative and suggestive, than forceful with your approach, no matter what type of content it is. You'll also need to sound authentic. People love authenticity. Although, it may not be something you find from the jump, you will learn to grow into it with consistency. It is only through consistency you can truly

identify what approach is most suitable for your type of content.

5. *“How do I know if my content is performing well?”*

— So to track your performance on Instagram, you need to switch to a professional account first; whether as a creator account or a business account. That way, you can view your post insights, check your reach and impressions overtime, and in that way, know what works and what doesn't work. For Twitter, you can check your tweet activity and for newsletters (e.g if you make use of Substack) and blogging platforms (e.g Medium, Wordpress, etc.), the stats are always provided for you.

6. *“Are paid ads necessary to promote my content?”*

— I strongly believe that as a writer, it is important for you to grow organically. Build your followers from the ground, up. I feel one of the greatest social media icks is seeing a page with 20k followers but with 100 likes. You don't want a situation like that because brands are averse to that, because they will believe that your followers are fake, because they kind of are, actually.

The only situation where paid ads may work in your favour is when you've been creating content for a while and you have enough to show on your page, so that those who are checking you out are invested in your work and become active followers, but this is very tricky still and I do not advise it at an early stage.

I'm a sucker for organic followers. That's community. You don't want to rush

it or get ahead of yourself. Let your content find people.

7. *“What do you do when the content you worked so hard on doesn’t perform as well as you wanted it to?”*

— I move on and create another one. If I worked so hard on it with my audience in mind and it still didn’t do as well as I wanted, I just move on and write some more. A lot of times, the problem isn’t the content but the timing, so it’s not exactly within my control what does insanely well and what doesn’t. You just move on and write again.

SIDE NOTE

Dear Beginner,

Becoming a full-fledged writer is not a day's job. Neither is it a month's or a year.

I have learnt that you can never truly be great at anything without consistency.

Talent is one thing. Talent is a gift you were given to make strides with, but what really makes you soar is consistency. Talent is never enough.

You see, over the years, I've realized that my passion for writing is not what builds me to be a great writer. A passion is just a hobby until a routine is put in place. So I decided to do just that - To not treat my writing as just another hobby but to feel more in-tune with it and always look for opportunities to write better.

It is quite difficult to get anything meaningful in life without having structure. A lack of structure makes one's mood to be in control of one's productivity.

I'm not saying we will always feel like writing, because sometimes even I do not. Instead, I am saying that we should be able to treat writing as a priority, because our desire to nurture something until it thrives is completely based on whether or not we see it as a priority.

I have also come to understand that growth is not a very comfortable process. And by 'not comfortable,' I do not mean toxic. I believe that people can grow just by leaving their comfort zone without getting into a toxic one.

Our body wants to sleep, eat and be on social media all day doing nothing, but feed on trends and content. If we let our bodies overcome our minds, we discover that we never achieve a thing. In a world where it is easier to become complacent and without purpose, we need to consistently choose to be better and do better.

I encourage you today to not just see content writing as yet another item to cross out on your bucket list. Your purchasing this ebook shows your interest in the writing and I'd like you to see this as an opportunity to let the world hear your voice and maybe also let yourself hear your own voice. It will surprise you how much you can say when you consistently try to discover.

Cheers on starting your writing journey! I hope it is amazing for you!

Best,

Simi.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Born in October 23, 1999, Similoluwa Kunle-Oni is a writer and a First Class graduate of Microbiology.

She enjoys spending time with family and friends. She also enjoys content writing, watching dramatic movies and listening to sonically pleasing music.

She is fully committed to living life and 'Notes on Content Writing and Brand Storytelling' is her third ebook.

